By Jumana Shah



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GUJARAT

TO BE AT HOME WITH GUJARATI

For a state formed on linguistic lines, it may come as a surprise that Gujarat took over six decades to make the teaching of its native language mandatory in elementary classes across all schools, irrespective of the medium of instruction or affiliation. In doing so, it has joined states like Maharashtra (which along with Gujarat was carved out from the erstwhile Bombay state in 1960), Punjab and Telangana that have passed similar legislations in recent years.

Titled the Gujarat Compulsory Teaching and Learning of Gujarati Language Bill, 2023, the proposed legislation got the state assembly's unanimous nod on February 28. It has basically given teeth to a 2018 government resolution (GR) that pushed for the teaching of Gujarati language even in non-Gujarati medium schools. Now, the schools that fail to comply will face a penalty of Rs 50,000, Rs 1 lakh and Rs 2 lakh for the first three violations, respectively, and can also lose their registration upon the third breach.

The immediate trigger for the state government to introduce the bill was last month's rap from the Gujarat High Court, which is hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) that seeks the implementation of the 2018 GR in its "true letter and spirit". According to the state's primary education department, only 14 of the 4,520 schools surveyed on the court's directions were not teaching Gujarati. But Ahmedabad-based NGO Matrubhasha Abhiyaan, which had moved the PIL, claimed the number of schools where Gujarati is not offered at all or is an optional subject is upwards of 100. Even as the court sought another survey to confirm numbers, the government decided to bring in the legislation.

According to Dr M.I. Joshi, director of primary education, Gujarat, non-domicile students whose parents are working in the state "for a temporary period" have been exempted from the mandatory learning of Gujarati, thus taking care of one of the potential sticking points. "Except for that, we have only encountered attitudinal resistance," he says. "Sure, schools will have to accommodate an additional subject but, within a year, these teething issues should be sorted." Claiming that schools were in any case expecting such a move following the GR in 2018, Joshi says it will also help create job opportunities for youths who graduate in Gujarati language.

Rajendra Patel, a trustee of the Matrubhasha Abhiyaan, claims that it's "well-established scientifically" that primary education must be in the mother tongue for a student to understand the basic concepts properly. "We do not undermine the importance of English as the language of higher technical education and business. But proficiency in English need not be at the cost of the mother tongue," he adds. Even the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020 recommends the mother tongue to be the medium of instruction until at least Class 5, and preferably till Class 8 and beyond.

A NEW STATE LAW MAKES GUJARATI A MANDATORY SUBJECT IN CLASSES 1-8; ERRANT SCHOOLS WILL FACE THE MUSIC

To set the record straight, the present legislation only makes Gujarati a mandatory subject in Classes 1-8 and in no way suggests that it should be the medium of instruction in schools. There are 9,965 primary schools in Gujarat, where about 3.1 million children are enrolled. Of these, 6,018 schools with 2.5 million students have Gujarati as the medium of instruction. It leaves about 20 per cent of the state's schoolchildren who are being instructed in